

# Claude Code, from *zero*.

Claude Code turns plain English into working software, in your own project, on your own computer. **You do not need to know how to code.** You need to know what you want and how to check that you got it. The rest of it is on this card.



## 01 • THE FIRST FIVE MINUTES

```
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
```

Once, ever. Needs Node 18+ from nodejs.org

```
cd my-project
```

It only ever sees the folder you start it in

```
claude
```

That is the whole thing. Sign in when the browser opens

```
/init
```

It reads your project and writes itself a briefing. Never skip

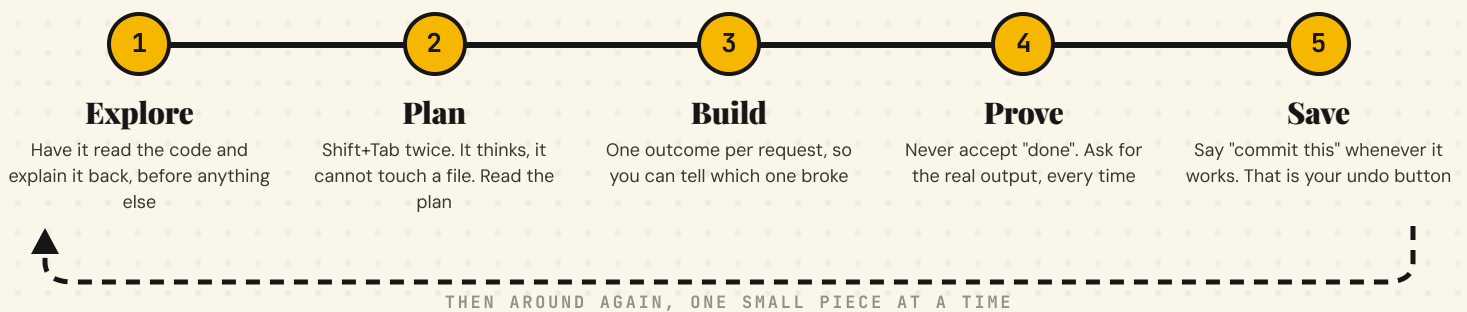
## 02 • YOUR FIRST TWENTY MINUTES

- ☐ Install Node, then Claude Code
- ☐ Open a terminal in your project folder
- ☐ Type claude and sign in
- ☐ Run /init, then read what it wrote about you
- ☐ Ask it to explain your own project back to you
- ☐ Press Esc mid-answer, so you know that you can

Ask it about your own code, not "hello", so you can judge the answer. It is also the fastest way to learn what your project actually does.

## 03 • THE LOOP THAT ACTUALLY WORKS

Almost every bad result comes from jumping straight to Build. This is the whole method.



## 04 • SAY IT LIKE THIS

INSTEAD OF

"make the site look better"

SAY

"On the homepage at 390px wide the hero button wraps onto three lines. Keep it on one line down to 320px, without dropping the text below 16px."

INSTEAD OF

"is this any good?"

SAY

"Find the three things most likely to break this in production, worst first, with the file and line. Do not tell me what is good about it."



KEEP GOING

### The whole guide, free.

Seventeen prompts you can copy with one tap, the CLAUDE.md template, all twelve rules, and a plain English glossary. No signup.

[modernmustardseed.com/fieldguide](https://modernmustardseed.com/fieldguide)



OR HAND IT OFF

### Stuck? Or want it built?

Call (406) 312-1223 and Mr. Mustard, our own AI agent, picks up at any hour. Or book thirty minutes and bring nothing but the idea.

[modernmustardseed.com/book](https://modernmustardseed.com/book)



# The reference

Anything in [BRACKETS] is yours to replace. That is the only editing these need.

## PROMPTS THAT DO THE WORK

### Explain my project to me

#### YOUR VERY FIRST REAL PROMPT IN ANY CODEBASE

Read this project and explain it like I have never seen it: what it does, the five files that matter most, and the one thing most likely to break. No jargon, and do not write any code.

### Plan it before you build it EVERY FEATURE BIGGER THAN A TYPO

I want to add [THE FEATURE]. Read the code that already does something similar, then plan it: the approach, every file you would change, what could go wrong. Plan only, no code.

### The error prompt

#### ANYTHING RED IN YOUR TERMINAL OR BROWSER CONSOLE

[PASTE THE WHOLE ERROR] Reproduce this first. Tell me the cause in one sentence. Then fix it and show me the run that proves it.

### The honest review BEFORE YOU SHOW ANYONE ANYTHING

Review this as the engineer who maintains it after I quit. Every problem, worst first, with the file and line. Do not list strengths.

### Put it on the internet

#### YOU HAVE SOMETHING WORKING LOCALLY AND NO IDEA WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

I want this live on the internet at a real address. One step at a time, wait for me after each, and tell me any cost before I commit.

## COMMANDS WORTH KNOWING

|                            |                                                          |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>/clear</code>        | Next task, clean slate. Use it more than feels necessary |
| <code>/compact</code>      | Long job, same thread, running out of room               |
| <code>/rewind</code>       | It broke something. Put the code and the chat back       |
| <code>/init</code>         | First time in a project. Writes the briefing             |
| <code>/permissions</code>  | Stop approving the same safe command forever             |
| <code>/agents</code>       | A specialist with its own instructions and memory        |
| <code>/help</code>         | The true, current list for your version                  |
| <code>claude -c</code>     | Continue the last conversation where you left it         |
| <code>claude -r</code>     | Pick an older conversation from a list                   |
| <code>claude update</code> | Get the newest version                                   |

## WHEN IT GOES SIDeways

|                                                        |                                                                                    |
|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>It changed files I never mentioned</b>              | Rewind, then name the file and the single outcome you want                         |
| <b>It got slow and started making dumb mistakes</b>    | Clear the session and restate the goal in five lines                               |
| <b>It is confidently wrong about a tool or library</b> | Make it read the actual installed source, or run the tool with <code>--help</code> |
| <b>It says it fixed it and it is not fixed</b>         | Ask for the real output, every time, before you believe anything                   |
| <b>It broke something that used to work</b>            | Rewind, or restore from git, then commit far more often                            |

## THE KEYS, AND THE FOUR CHARACTERS THAT DO WORK

**Esc**

Stop it now, keep everything so far

**Esc Esc**

Go back and edit an earlier message

**Shift+Tab**

Cycle: ask, auto-accept, plan mode

**Up arrow**

Your previous prompts

**Ctrl+C**

Cancel. Twice quits



Opens the command list for your exact version



Point at a file or folder as you type



Start a line with this to save a rule into memory permanently



Run a terminal command yourself without leaving the session

## THE TWELVE RULES, LEARNED THE EXPENSIVE WAY

- 01 Done is not evidence.** Load the real URL yourself. A green terminal is a claim.
- 02 Never let it guess at a command.** Make it run `--help`. Invented options look exactly like real ones.
- 03 Two failed attempts means the plan is wrong.** Stop patching. Back to plan mode, ask for another approach.
- 04 Save at every working state.** "Commit this." Turns any disaster into a five second undo.
- 05 Give it the error, all of it.** Paste every line. Your paraphrase deletes the part that solves it.
- 06 One session, one job.** Two sessions on the same files overwrite each other quietly.
- 07 Secrets never enter the chat.** No keys in CLAUDE.md. Not even to test.
- 08 Read the plan like it costs money.** Thirty seconds there is the best time you spend all day.
- 09 It agrees with you by default.** Never ask "is this right". Ask "what breaks first, and why".
- 10 Fresh memory beats clever wording.** Going dumb? Clear it and restate the goal in five lines.
- 11 You own the output.** Fastest hands you have ever had. Still your name on it.
- 12 Build small, ship it, then grow it.** The only wrong move is planning for a month.